Erev Rosh Hashanah · Shabbos Nitzavim–Vayeilech • Diburim

Shanah Tovah U'Metukah

The Taste of Revealed Good

Dibur · Bracha · Shofar · Nitzavim

I. A Liba Esther Question

Shanah tovah u'metukah. A good and sweet New Year. It is Erev Rosh Hashanah, and this year the first day of Rosh Hashanah falls on Shabbos itself.

We have not had a Liba Esther question in a little while, but this one was particularly beautiful. She asked recently: Tati, why do we wish people a shanah tovah u'metukah? Why do we also have to wish them a sweet New Year? Both children have a serious sweet tooth, each of them, which is a whole separate topic. But the question itself goes far beyond sweetness. Why isn't shanah tovah enough? What does metukah add that tov does not already include?

Before answering that, though, there is an earlier question hiding inside Liba Esther's question. Why do we wish one another anything at all? Why does one Jew give another Jew a bracha? That question leads us somewhere worth going.

II. Hashem Created the World Through Speech

The Torah introduces us to all of reality through speech. The opening chapter of Bereishis repeats it again and again:

וַיֹּאמֶר אֱלֹקִים

"And God said."

Hashem speaks, and reality comes into existence. Light exists because Hashem says yehi or. Creation itself emerges through dibur. Then the Torah creates Adam HaRishon. Hashem forms him from the earth and breathes into him a nishmas chaim, and Adam becomes a nefesh chayah. Onkelos understands this as a ruach memalela, a speaking spirit. The power of speech is not incidental to what a human being is. It expresses something fundamental about it.

Adam's first great act in the world is to name the creatures. A name does more than label something. It allows us to identify, to distinguish, to call, and to enter into relationship.

When Hashem speaks to Adam, to Kayin after the death of Hevel, to the Avos and then to Moshe Rabbeinu, there is dialogue. And dialogue has an extraordinary capacity to build relationship. It can also damage and destroy relationship. More fundamentally, speech is one of the basic conditions for relationship at all.

Anyone who works with people knows this. Working in business, the difference between sending a client an email and actually speaking with them by phone or video is enormous. The exact same sentence reads one way on a screen and sounds completely different once you hear the person's voice. The same is true with friends. A WhatsApp message can be read twenty different ways. Tone is missing. Inflection is missing. Warmth is missing. When you hear someone's voice, the entire paradigm of the interaction changes.

III. A Bracha Is More Than Politeness

This helps us understand why one Jew gives another Jew a bracha. Before the meraglim enter Eretz Yisrael, Moshe Rabbeinu renames Hoshea bin Nun as Yehoshua. Chazal understand this as a tefillah: Yah yoshiecha mei'atzas meraglim, may Hashem save you from the counsel of the spies. Moshe does not merely think, I hope Yehoshua will be all right. The hope becomes dibur. It becomes tefillah. It becomes bracha.

That is a fundamental pattern of Torah life. We do not merely think gratitude. We make a bracha. We do not merely contemplate the Shema. We say it. We do not merely possess words of tefillah conceptually. We daven. Halacha repeatedly gives articulation independent significance. The spoken word has a standing that thought alone does not possess.

Chassidus describes machshavah, dibur, and maaseh as the three levushim through which the nefesh expresses itself in the world. Thought, speech, action. Something begins inside as a thought. It receives form and expression through speech. From there it can enter the world through action. As we sing every Friday night:

סוֹף מַעֲשֶׂה בְּמַחֲשָׁבָה תְּחִלָּה

"The final action begins in the initial thought."

Rabbi Gerzi recently told us of a tzaddik who was particular not to make a bracha when there was nobody present to answer amen, because he understood the weight of using

dibur in a good, yashar, kosher way. That is not excessive caution. That is a deep recognition of what speech actually is.

IV. Speech Can Also Destroy

Precisely because speech is powerful, it can also be profoundly dangerous. Chazal speak with extraordinary severity about nival peh, debased and vulgar speech. The Gemara in Shabbos describes harsh communal consequences associated with it. That gravity is not accidental. Speech that is corrupted does real damage in the world.

The same is true of hateful speech. Sinas chinam destroyed the second Beis HaMikdash, and one of the easiest ways for hatred to become concrete and acted upon is through words. A relationship can be destroyed by what is said. And sometimes it can be destroyed through what is refused: the silent treatment, pushing someone out, refusing relationship entirely. Even that refusal is a form of speech, a communication of exclusion.

Words bring another person into my world. The words I choose to speak toward another person, or to withhold, shape what exists between us. That is why the words we use on Rosh Hashanah carry particular weight.

V. Why Sweet, Not Only Good?

Which brings us back to Liba Esther. Shanah tovah u'metukah. Why not simply shanah tovah?

Tov and matok are not the same thing. There are things in life that are ultimately good but do not feel good while they are happening. We believe Hashem is good. We believe His ratzon is good. We believe reality is governed by Hashem and that what He does is ultimately for the good. But believing that something is ultimately good is not the same thing as being able to taste the goodness while we are living through it.

Someone loses a job. In retrospect, perhaps that person finds a better position, a healthier environment, better hours, more time with family, better parnassah. Looking backward they might say, now I understand. But when the job was lost, it hurt. It was bitter. Someone is forced to move, and later discovers a better community, a better home, a better situation altogether. But while packing the boxes, it may not feel good. The good was present but hidden. The good was real but not yet revealed.

Sweetness is different. Sweetness is experienced. When something sweet touches the tongue, there is no need for a philosophical argument that perhaps ten years from now you will understand why it was worth it. You taste it now. You experience it directly. It has a taam.

Perhaps that is what we are asking Hashem for. Not merely that the din should ultimately be good. Not merely that the gezeirah should ultimately be revealed as good. We are asking that the goodness should be something we can experience as good while it is happening. Something we can taste. Something we can recognize. The Torah tells us that Hashem is good, and we say amen to that. The bracha of Rosh Hashanah adds: this year, please let us taste it. Let the tov be revealed enough to become matok.

VI. Why I Need Your Year to Be Sweet

And now the bracha from one Jew to another becomes much deeper. Of course each person wants a sweet year for himself. But there is something more. A person needs his wife to have a sweet year. He needs his children to have a sweet year. He needs his friends to have a sweet year.

Perhaps I can tell myself during a difficult period that everything Hashem does is for the good. But when I look at someone I love, I do not want merely to say, I hope you eventually discover why your suffering was worthwhile. I want better than that for the people around me. I want revealed good. I want them to taste sweetness not in hindsight but while it is unfolding. And perhaps even more difficult but even more important: I should be capable of wanting that sincerely for the person I find difficult. Because:

אַתֶּם נִצָּבִים הַיּוֹם כֻּלְּכֶם

"All of you are standing here today."

— Devarim 29:9

Nitzavim, the parsha we just read, places all of Klal Yisrael together. How do human beings become together? Primarily through speech. I speak. You hear. You respond. Relationship is created. And perhaps that gives us a bridge toward Haazinu, which will be read after Rosh Hashanah this year. Haazinu, listen, turn your ear toward something, receive. Speech only becomes relationship when there is someone willing to hear.

VII. From Individual to Communal to Beyond Words

Chazal gave Klal Yisrael a shared structure of tefillah. Yes, there are different nuschaos: Ashkenaz, Sefard, Nusach Ari, Edot HaMizrach, and variations within each tradition. Each has its own taam, its own particular flavor. And yet we come together in minyan and speak before Hashem as a tzibbur. There are tefillos said quietly. There are piyutim sung together. There are words led by the chazzan on behalf of the community. Individual dibur and communal dibur flow into one another.

But eventually language reaches its limit. Sometimes no poem can fully express what is inside a Jew on Rosh Hashanah. Sometimes no paragraph, no sentence, no carefully chosen word can contain fear, hope, love, regret, memory, longing, and coronation simultaneously. There is a point where words are simply not sufficient.

That is where the shofar enters. The Torah does not call this day Rosh Hashanah. It calls it:

זִכְרוֹן תְּרוּעָה

"A remembrance of the shofar blast."
— Vayikra 23:24

The sound is built into the Torah's very description of the day. The central sections of Musaf are Malchiyos, Zichronos, and Shofros. Malchiyos is coronation, accepting Hashem as King. Zichronos is memory, asking that our remembrance rise before Hashem for good. Shofros carries us into the sound itself, into the great moments of Jewish history associated with the shofar, and ultimately into what cannot be said in words at all.

The Gemara discusses whether the Torah's teruah means a longer broken groaning sound or a rapid crying sound, and because of that uncertainty we sound both. Inside those sounds we can perhaps hear different parts of the Rosh Hashanah experience. The tekiah is whole and strong. The shevarim is broken, a groan from a heart that recognizes it is not yet complete. The teruah is rapid weeping, the sound that arrives when words have failed entirely. How do I tell Hashem that He is my King? I say it. And then I have to sound it. How do I hold fear and hope and love and shame and longing together in a single moment? Often I cannot. So the shofar speaks for me.

VIII. This Year the Shofar Is Silent on Shabbos

There is one extraordinary additional dimension this year. The first day of Rosh Hashanah is Shabbos. And the halacha is that when Rosh Hashanah falls on Shabbos, we do not blow the shofar outside the Beis HaMikdash. On the very day the Torah calls yom teruah, the shofar is silent.

That silence does not weaken the message. Perhaps it sharpens it. Rosh Hashanah teaches us that our relationship with Hashem does not depend on any single mode of communication. There is speech. There is sound. There is listening. And sometimes there is silence that holds everything inside it. Even the shofar, the cry that goes beyond words, can be held back because Hashem's Torah tells us that this Shabbos asks something different of us. And yet the longing for the shofar remains. The Malchiyos, Zichronos, and Shofros remain. On the second day, the sound returns.

IX. The Taste of Revealed Good

So perhaps Liba Esther's question was much bigger than it first appeared. Why do we wish one another a sweet year? Because words matter. Because the way one Jew speaks to another Jew matters. Because on the day when each of us stands before Hashem as an individual and as a community, the bracha I give you is not merely a seasonal greeting.

Shanah tovah u'metukah is a statement about relationship. I want good for you. More than that, I want you to be able to experience that good. I want the good to be visible and felt and tasted. I do not merely want Hashem to decree a good year for you that you will understand in twenty years. I want you to taste it now. I want my wife to taste it. I want my children to taste it. I want my friends to taste it. And I should want that sincerely even for the person I find difficult, because all of us are standing here together:

אַתֶּם נִצָּבִים הַיּוֹם כֻּלְּכֶם

On Rosh Hashanah we stand before the Melech together, every single one of us. If each person can look at the people around him and sincerely say from the pnimius, I want you to have a shanah tovah u'metukah, perhaps that itself is part of what it means to stand together before Hashem. Not merely believing that everything He does is good. Not merely asking that the gezeiros should ultimately be good. Asking that this year, the

goodness should be revealed enough that we can taste it. That the tov should become matok.

May we all be granted a year of real, pure, beautiful sweetness. A shanah tovah u'metukah.

חזק ואחזק

Good Shabbos

Shanah Tovah U'Metukah

Reflection Questions

- *Is there something in my life right now that I believe is ultimately good but cannot yet taste as good? What would it mean to ask Hashem this year for revealed sweetness rather than only hidden good?*
- *When I wish someone a shanah tovah u'metukah, am I genuinely wanting revealed good for them, or am I saying the words as a habit? What would it feel like to say it and truly mean the sweetness?*
- *Rabbi Gerzi speaks about not being brains on a stem, about Torah being experiential and lived. Where in my avodah this year have I been saying the words without the taste? What would it mean to bring the taam back?*
- *The shofar on Rosh Hashanah reaches past words to where words can no longer go. What is the longing inside me this year that I have not found words for? What would I say to Hashem if I sounded my own shofar right now?*
- *Attem nitzavim hayom kulchem: all of us stand here together. Is there someone in my life toward whom I have been withholding real warmth, even in speech? Can I sincerely wish that person a shanah tovah u'metukah this year?*
- *This year Rosh Hashanah falls on Shabbos and the shofar is silent on the first day. What does the silence ask of me? What do I hear inside it that the sound itself might not have reached?*